

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

2013-05-16

To the delegates gathered at

171 26 16 May 2013 To the delegates gathered at Bahá'í National Conventions Dear Bahá'í Friends, 26.1 The Eleventh International Convention, recently concluded,

offered all who were present a glimpse of the promise of Bahá'u'lláh to unite the peoples of the world. More than a thousand members of one hundred and fifty-seven National Spiritual Assemblies attended, and nearly five hundred more, including those from an additional fourteen countries, participated in the election by mail. This diverse group of women and men, a veritable cross section of humanity, evinced, in their participation in the electoral process and subsequent contributions to the Convention consultations, a spirit of sanctity and love, a unity of thought and purpose, and a consecration to the collective enterprise of applying the healing message of Bahá'u'lláh that earned our deep admiration. No doubt, the members of your National Assembly, or the Counsellors, will share with you the joyous fellowship they experienced and the insights they gained during the productive days spent in the Holy Land.

26.2 You now gather in National Conventions to carry out your own sacred responsibilities in the Bahá'í Administrative Order.

Foremost is the election of the members of your National Assembly, when you will choose individuals who can meet the pressing requirements of the progress of the Cause at the present stage of its development. Our letter dated 25 March 2007 was intended to strengthen the Bahá'í electoral process, and we urge you to give renewed consideration to its salient points. In the features and outcomes of this electoral process that distinguish it from contemporary practices we find not limitations, but dawning points of profound implication. The delegates, as well as the generality of the believers, uphold the 172 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONpurity of Bahá'í elections, scrupulously avoiding electioneering or discussion of who should or should not be a member, even when specific names are not mentioned; for not only does the Guardian prohibit reference to particular personalities, but he also states that “we should refrain from influencing the opinions of others.” Collectively, the friends strive to purge themselves of every trace of worldly tendencies—pursuit of personal ambitions, promotion of individuals, contest, and partisanship—which can corrupt and distort an election’s spiritual character. Delegates are obliged to become “intelligent, well-informed and responsible” electors so as to “be able to make a wise choice at the election time.” They enjoy the unfettered right to choose from among all those eligible, whether it be to retain members or to select new ones. The community wholeheartedly embraces the result of the election, confident that the delegates have cast their ballots for those for whom prayer and reflection have inspired them to vote.

26.3 Within the administrative arrangements of the Bahá'í

community there are a number of spaces that allow for the exchange of views, including cluster reflection gatherings, institutional meetings, and the Nineteen Day Feast. The National Convention is another such occasion, but unique in that it brings together the

National Assembly and elected representatives from all parts of the country. The conduct of this consultative dimension of the Convention calls for thoughtful attention.

26.4 Shoghi Effendi stated that the National Convention should

“fulfill the functions of an enlightened, consultative and cooperative body that will enrich the experience, enhance the prestige, support the authority, and assist the deliberations of the National Spiritual Assembly.” Although delegates are to offer their views in a full, frank, and unhampered manner, he advised that time not be spent on problems of secondary importance and that disruptive forces, “which are but the outcome of human passion and selfishness,” should be resisted. Instead, the Guardian expected those assembled to “approach their task with absolute detachment” and “concentrate their attention on the most important and pressing issues” in order to obtain a “deeper and broader vision of the Cause through an increase in the spirit of unity and of wholehearted cooperation.” “The unfettered freedom of the individual should be tempered with mutual consultation and sacrifice,” he explained, “and the spirit 173

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]